

MT.3 Inspection Sequence

Who inspects a Montana house — which in much of the state is almost nobody — how the electrical inspection and the power-supplier release actually work, and the record you have to build yourself when no inspector is coming.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Montana's building code does not apply to a residential building of fewer than five dwelling units unless the local legislative body has adopted it (50-60-102(1)(a), MCA) — but the electrical permit, the energy code, and all of water and wastewater law survive that exemption, on separate tracks with separate offices. Confirm every item with the office that will actually issue it. Where a certified local building program has jurisdiction, its permit card lists the inspections your job requires and it governs. The electrical inspection is additional to it unless that same jurisdiction is certified for electrical too.

FIRST DECIDE WHICH MONTANA YOU ARE BUILDING IN

Everything on the following pages branches on one fact you settled in MT.1: has the county, city, or town where your parcel sits adopted the state building code for residential buildings of fewer than five dwelling units, and is its enforcement program certified under 50-60-302? If yes, you get a conventional ladder and a certificate of occupancy at the end. If no, the state *"may not enforce"* the building code for your house (50-60-102(2)) — **no plan review, no framing inspection, no certificate of occupancy** — and the only inspection anyone performs is the electrical one.

The same house, two completely different inspection regimes

Discipline	Inside a certified local program	Outside one — most of Montana by area
Building	Full ladder: footing through final, plus plan review. Certificate of occupancy issued at the end (50-60-106(2)(e); 50-60-107).	None. The state may not enforce the code for your house (50-60-102(2)) and no local program exists to. Nobody visits.
Electrical	Local, if the jurisdiction is certified for electrical; otherwise still the Department of Labor & Industry (50-60-604). Ask — certification is per craft.	Required. DLI inspects and issues the permit (50-60-604). This is the only inspection most rural Montana houses ever get.
Plumbing	Local permit and inspection where a local code covers plumbing and provides inspection procedures — which removes the state permit (50-60-506(3)).	No permit at all if you personally do the work as owner of the residential property (50-60-506(4)). Nobody inspects it either.
Energy	Verified through the local program where the building is subject to the code.	You certify it yourself , in writing, at the end (50-60-102(5)(b)(ii); 50-60-802(1)).

The same house, two completely different inspection regimes

Discipline	Inside a certified local program	Outside one — most of Montana by area
Septic and water	County and DEQ, on their own schedule — unchanged either way. See MT.2.	County and DEQ, on their own schedule — unchanged either way. See MT.2.

50-60-102(2), (5)(b)(ii); 50-60-106(2)(e); 50-60-107; 50-60-302; 50-60-506(3), (4); 50-60-604; 50-60-802(1), MCA. Read August 2026. Certification is granted per discipline, so a jurisdiction can run a building program and leave electrical with the state — confirm each separately (MT.4).

THE ELECTRICAL INSPECTION — THE ONE THAT ALWAYS HAPPENS

Whoever else does or does not visit your site, this one does. The statute names who: "*The department of labor and industry or an authorized representative or a county, city, or town certified to perform an inspection pursuant to 50-60-302 shall inspect electrical installations, issue electrical permits for these installations, and establish and charge a reasonable and uniform fee*" (50-60-604). Three operational facts follow from that sentence and the two after it.

What the electrical statute actually obliges

Point	What it means on your job
Buy the permit first	The permit is the thing your power supplier will demand, and it is issued by DLI or a certified local program — not by your electrician's goodwill. A homeowner relying on the exemption in 37-68-103(3)(a) still buys it, because that exemption reaches the license only (MT.1).
Expect to show licenses	"As part of any inspection, the inspector shall require proof of licensure from any person who is required to be licensed who is involved with or, in the inspector's judgment, appears to be involved with electrical installations if the person is on the site" (50-60-604). Violations are reported to the board of electricians. If a friend is helping you wire, understand what that means before inspection day.
Inspectors cover distance	Montana is the fourth-largest state by area with a small number of electrical inspectors. Book early, be specific about directions to a rural site, and have the work genuinely ready — a wasted trip on a two-hour drive is not a rescheduling, it is a week. Confirm the current scheduling method with the office that issued your permit and write it in the block below.

The mechanics, from the department's own rules

How the state electrical inspection actually runs

Point	The rule
Two inspections	Not a long ladder — a cover (rough-in) inspection and a final . The permittee, "whether an electrical contractor or a homeowner," notifies the area inspector when the work is ready (ARM 24.301.441). On approval at final the inspector applies a green approved tag (ARM 24.301.451).
The 48-hour rule — read this before you insulate	<i>"Insulation and wallboard shall not be applied prior to inspection unless 48 hours, excluding Saturdays, Sundays and holidays, have expired after the electrical installation is complete and notice to inspect has been received"</i> (ARM 24.301.441). That is a genuine self-release valve for a remote site: give proper notice, wait two business days, and you may close up. Document the notice and the date.
Permits run 18 months	Valid 18 months , with one 18-month renewal (ARM 24.301.431(9)). An owner-build routinely outruns the first term — put the expiry in your calendar the day you buy it. A transfer form exists if the permit needs to move.
Order of operations	No electrical permit issues until the building permit has been issued <i>"or it has been determined that a building permit is not required"</i> (ARM 24.301.431(12)). For an exempt house that determination is the thing you supply — the department provides for the owner to establish the exemption in writing (ARM 24.301.142(4)). Expect to say so in the application, and keep a copy.

ARM 24.301.431(9), (12); 24.301.441; 24.301.451; 24.301.142(4). The department reproduces these rules in its Electrical Information Pamphlet, which it labels unofficial guidance — read the rules themselves before relying on a deadline. Read August 2026.

The finish line is the meter, not the final

*"Except for temporary connections that the department of labor and industry may authorize by rule for a period **not exceeding 14 days** without a preconnection inspection, **power suppliers may not connect with or energize an electrical installation under this part unless the owner or a licensed electrical contractor has delivered to the power supplier an electrical permit covering the installation**" (50-60-605). "Power suppliers" expressly includes **cooperatives** and municipalities — a rural electric co-op is bound exactly as an investor-owned utility is.*

And energizing around them is a crime: any person other than a power supplier who energizes an installation for which no electrical permit has been issued *"is guilty of a **misdemeanor**"* (50-60-607). That reaches the temptation everyone on a long rural build eventually has — backfeeding the panel from a generator to run heat while you finish. Sort the permit out first.

The permit is also your cut-in card. Montana's mechanism is unusually simple: the utility may energize provisionally on receipt of **the power supplier's copy of the electrical permit** (ARM 24.301.431(5)), with the provisional designation removed when the final passes. A certified local jurisdiction may additionally demand proof of an approved inspection first. Montana's largest investor-owned utility says it plainly in its own new-service documents: *"According to Montana law, you must obtain and provide our New Construction office a copy of an electrical permit."* Rural cooperatives ask for the same thing.

Plan the sequence backwards from the connection date. Ask your power supplier, early and in writing: line extension cost and lead time; how much footage is included before charges start; whether it wants a temporary construction service and how long that lasts; who digs, and who supplies trench, conduit, and pull rope; and how long after your electrical final it schedules the meter set. Expect it to require a **permanent assigned address** before it will do anything — on a rural build the utility, not the county, is usually what forces you to go get one. On a remote parcel the line extension is routinely the longest lead item on the whole job, ahead of anything a permit office does.

50-60-604, 50-60-605, 50-60-607, MCA; 37-68-103(3)(a), MCA. Read August 2026. The 14-day temporary connection is authorized by rule — confirm the current rule in ARM Title 24, chapter 301 at rules.mt.gov and confirm the practice with your own power supplier.

THE TYPICAL LADDER — AND WHO OWNS EACH RUNG

No Montana statute enumerates residential inspections; where a certified program has jurisdiction, its adopted code and permit card do. The order below is the **typical** shape an IRC-based code produces, annotated with what happens on the same rung when no building program has jurisdiction. Verify names and count against your own permit card.

Typical order — the permit card governs where one exists

Inspection	Whose	What must be complete
1. Footing / setback	LOCAL — or nobody	Forms and steel before concrete. Where nobody inspects, this is the rung to hire your own engineer for: a footing is unreachable afterwards.
2. Foundation / damproofing	LOCAL — or nobody	Before backfill. Frost depth in Montana runs deep and is set locally; confirm the figure for your site in writing and record it.
3. Underground plumbing / slab	LOCAL — or nobody	Under-slab drain, waste, and vent tested before the pour. No state plumbing inspection exists where you did the work yourself under 50-60-506(4).
4. Rough electrical	DLI or certified LOCAL	Wiring complete and open. This one happens everywhere. Book it early — the inspector may be driving a long way.

Typical order — the permit card governs where one exists

Inspection	Whose	What must be complete
5. Rough plumbing	LOCAL — or nobody	Local where a local code covers plumbing with inspection procedures (50-60-506(3)); otherwise not inspected if you did it yourself.
6. Framing / sheathing	LOCAL — or nobody	Where a local program is involved this is called after the trade rough-ins pass, including the electrical one it does not control.
7. Insulation and air barrier	LOCAL — or YOU	Against the adopted energy code. Where nobody inspects, this is the rung your own energy certification will rest on — photograph it.
8. Final electrical	DLI or certified LOCAL	The approval that releases the power supplier to set a permanent meter (50-60-605).
9. Septic final	COUNTY / DEQ	Before the system is covered and before it is used — the county's sequence, not the building department's. See MT.2.
10. Building final / CO	LOCAL only	Only where a certified local program has jurisdiction (50-60-106(2)(e); 50-60-107). Elsewhere there is no certificate of occupancy — see below.
11. Energy certification	YOU	"At the conclusion of construction" the builder certifies in writing to the owner (50-60-802(1)). As owner-builder you are both.

If a certified program does have your job

Two rules worth holding it to. Its inspectors must themselves be **state-licensed journeymen in the craft they are inspecting**, or certified by an approved national body (50-60-302(1)(c)). And the department publishes a **single-family dwelling checklist** that certified jurisdictions must make available; a contractor who attaches a completed one to the plans is entitled to the building permit or a notice of plan disapproval **within 10 working days** (50-60-106(2)(c)). Ask for that checklist by name — it is the closest thing Montana publishes to a statewide submittal list, and it comes with a clock attached.

WHEN NOBODY IS COMING — BUILD THE RECORD YOURSELF

This is the part of Montana owner-building that costs people money years later. Where no building program has jurisdiction there is no plan review, no inspection card, and **no certificate of occupancy** — so when a lender's appraiser, an insurance underwriter, or a buyer's home inspector asks what this house was built to and who checked, the honest answer is whatever you can document. Nobody else is keeping that record. Collect these as you go, not at the end:

- ☐ **The electrical permit and the final electrical approval**, plus whatever your power supplier accepted before setting the meter (50-60-605). This is the one genuinely independent inspection your house received — it is worth more to a future buyer than you think.
- ☐ **Your written energy certification** under 50-60-802(1), naming the adopted edition you built to, dated and signed at the conclusion of construction — with the insulation R-values, window U-factors, and equipment efficiencies you actually installed listed on it.
- ☐ **The septic permit, the approved design, and the county's final approval**, plus any as-built the county requires — and the **well log or water-supply documentation** and whatever you filed with DNRC (MT.2).
- ☐ **The structural basis of the roof**: the ground snow load figure you designed to, where it came from, and any engineer's letter, calculation, or stamped truss package. In a state where nobody checks this, the documentation *is* the assurance.
- ☐ **Photographs of everything that gets covered** — footing steel before the pour, foundation waterproofing before backfill, framing connections, plumbing tests, insulation and air sealing before drywall. Date them. This is the substitute for an inspection card, and it is free.
- ☐ **Receipts and product data** for the assemblies that matter: windows, insulation, roofing, trusses, the panel and service equipment. Keep them with the certification, not in a shoebox.

INSPECTION AND MILESTONE LOG

Log every inspection that happens — and every milestone that passes with nobody watching. Where no inspector signs a card, this page is the card.

Record every stage as it happens — nobody else keeps this record

Stage	Authority / self	Called	Held	Result	Corrections / photos taken / notes
Footing / setback					
Foundation / dampproofing					
Underground plumbing / slab					
Rough electrical					
Rough plumbing					
Framing / sheathing					
Insulation / air barrier					
Final electrical					
Power supplier — permit delivered					

Record every stage as it happens — nobody else keeps this record

Stage	Authority / self	Called	Held	Result	Corrections / photos taken / notes
Septic final					
Building final / CO (if any)					
Energy certification signed					

Electrical inspector / office: _____ Permit #: _____ Issued: _____

Power supplier: _____ Meter set: _____ CO issued: _____

Ground snow load designed to: _____ Source: _____

Sources — every Montana claim in this document (verified August 2026)

What this document states	Authority
The state may not enforce the building code for residential buildings of fewer than five dwelling units	50-60-102(2), MCA
The energy provisions are enforced for those buildings through builder self-certification	50-60-102(5)(b)(ii); 50-60-802(1), MCA
Electrical inspections and permits by DLI or a certified county, city, or town; the inspector must require proof of licensure on site	50-60-604, MCA
No power supplier — including a cooperative — may connect or energize without the electrical permit delivered to it; temporary connections up to 14 days by rule	50-60-605, MCA
Energizing an installation with no electrical permit is a misdemeanor	50-60-607, MCA
Certified locals examine plans, order remedies during construction, and issue certificates of occupancy	50-60-106(2)(a), (d), (e); 50-60-107, MCA
The department's single-family checklist and the 10-working-day permit-or-disapproval clock	50-60-106(2)(c), MCA
A local inspector must be a state-licensed journeyman in the craft inspected or nationally certified	50-60-302(1)(c), MCA
No state plumbing permit where a local code covers plumbing with inspection procedures; none at all where the owner personally does the work	50-60-506(3), (4), MCA

Read any **MCA** section cited above — Montana Code Annotated — at mca.legmt.gov, the Legislature's own server, which publishes each section with a History line naming every session law that amended it. Read any **ARM** rule — Administrative Rules of Montana; the building, electrical, plumbing, and mechanical code adoptions live in **Title 24, chapter 301** — at rules.mt.gov, where the rule text is official and carries its effective date. Search that site by rule number rather than following a saved link: it is a search application, deep links collapse back to the search page, and a bad address returns an apparently working but empty page rather than an error. Two habits will keep you out of trouble in Montana. **First, always check whether the answer is in the MCA or the ARM**, and go read that one — Montana keeps an unusual share of what governs your house in the rules rather than the code, including real conditions on the homeowner exemptions that appear in no statute at all. **Second, watch which chapter you are in** — Montana splits one house across Title 50, chapter 60 (the building, plumbing, and electrical permits) and Title 37, chapters 68 and 69 (the electrician and plumber licenses), and an exemption written in one of them cannot waive a duty written in the other. All statute and rule text in this kit verified August 2026.